

places: your community church, that harmonic dating Web site, and at your posh country club.

If I lose \$10,000 on an investment that I meticulously investigated, I can deal with it. Easy come, easy go. Yet, if I have \$10,000 stolen from me because I blindly trusted someone who I let into my vehicle, it's different. Today I trust no one but give everyone the opportunity to prove trust. There are a lot of good people in this world, and they do outnumber the bad by a wide margin. It just takes a mild effort to find them and keep them in your life. Just be careful who you pick up on the side of the road. Don't be tempted by a cold brew but be blinded to the chainsaw.

FIRE RECKLESS CHAUFFEURS

Are inmates running the asylum? When you're not home, who runs your castle? Who chauffeurs your business?

Providing great customer service is one thing; getting employees to deliver it is another. When you shift your focus to the bottom line, often the frontline is sacrificed. How much is that untrained \$8/hr. front desk person with a bad attitude really costing you? To make customers disciples of your business, employees have to share your customer service philosophy. You can't let any employee ruin a multimillion dollar investment. *All the intangibles in the world can't change a poor customer service experience.*

After a nine-day stay in Las Vegas I learned how robotic service is the ultimate of business liabilities, regardless of poshness. Most people vacation in Vegas to escape from coworkers, incompetent employees, dirty houses, traffic, and your typical menagerie of life's dramas. Vegas is supposed to be an escape. Compliments of my friend's company, which was participating in a convention, my Vegas stay started at the Rio Hotel. I had never stayed at the Rio and normally wouldn't consider this hotel. The hotel was somewhat hoary and dated; the bed was stiff and the accommodations worn. Nonetheless, I found the staff very nice. The dealers were friendly and the casino staff was accommodating to our minor requests. I enjoyed my stay.

After three days at the Rio, my hotel stay transferred over to the Venetian Hotel, a hotel that my American Express concierge arranged. For those unfamiliar with the Venetian, it is a new hotel with opulent architecture: ornate columns and corbels, lavish chandeliers, and other affluent appointments that would make anyone feel like royalty. My stay at the Venetian was for six days.

Unfortunately, after six days, I will never return.

Loved the fancy Italian architecture, but their people suck. Our nightmare started on day one and continued every single day, marred by poor human experiences: unresponsive housekeeping, unacceptable hold times to hotel services, failure to deliver promises, mechanized staff, overcharging, and, overall, a failure to provide an escape. There are two critical lessons in this experience: